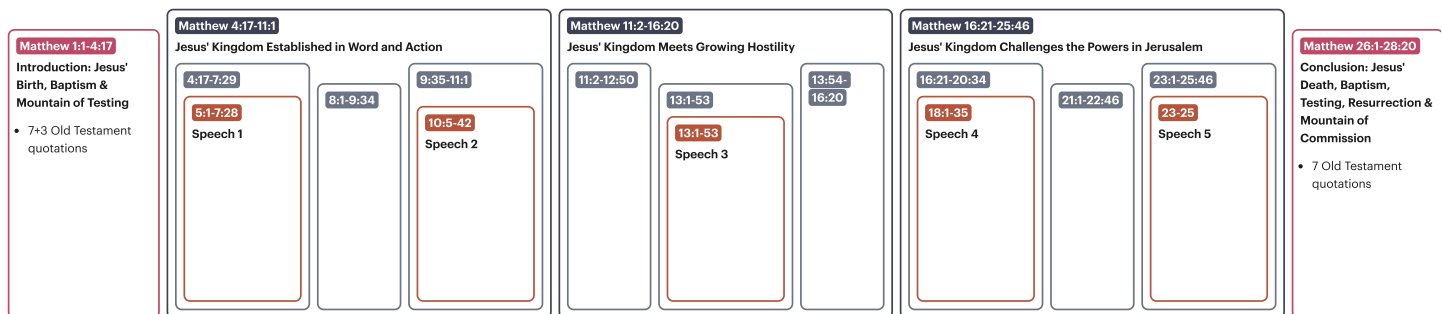


Session 3: Macro Design of Matthew's Gospel

Key Takeaways

- Matthew structures Jesus' teaching to reflect the teaching of Moses, showing how Jesus came to fill full the Torah.
- Matthew identifies Jesus as the Son of David, emphasizing how Jesus is the fulfillment of Israel's messianic hopes.
- Matthew portrays Jesus as the Son of Abraham, emphasizing how Jesus is the fulfillment of God's promise of blessing to all nations through Abraham and his descendants.
- Matthew presents Jesus as the Son of God and Son of Humanity, focusing on the claim of Jesus' divine and human identity.

The Macro Design of the Gospel According to Matthew



Matthew 1-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Matthew has carefully crafted his account with a matching introduction and conclusion.

- Matthew 1:1-4:17 introduces Jesus as the Son of Abraham, of David, and of God. He is born as a human, baptised and tested on a wilderness mountain, all marked by 7 + 3 quotations from Scripture (7 "fulfillment" quotes + 3 quotes).
- Matthew 26:1-28:20 brings Jesus' vocation as Son of David and Son of God to a climactic conclusion. He is tested in a garden, executed (= his "baptism"), resurrected, and then commissions his disciples on a mountain, all marked by 7 quotations from Scripture.

Between the introductory and concluding frames, Matthew 4:17-25:46 takes the story from Jesus' announcement of God's Kingdom (Matt. 4:12-17) to Jesus' final days in Jerusalem (Matt. 26:1-28:20). Matthew has organized this section in three large parts, the first and last of which have matching introductions that set the main theme for the unit.

Matthew 4:17 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Iesous began (απο τότε ηρξάτο ο Ιησους)

to announce and say,

"Change-direction!

Because the kingdom of the skies has come near!"

Matthew 16:21 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Iesous began (απο τότε ηρξάτο ο Ιησους)

to point out that it was necessary for him to go to Ierosolima,

and to suffer many things by the elders and chief-priests and scribes,

and to be killed,

and on the third day, to be raised up.

These introductions are coordinated with the conclusions to the five matching speeches.

Matthew 7:28 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Iesous finished (ετελεσεν) **these words ...**

Matthew 11:1 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when he finished (ετελεσεν) **instructing his twelve apprentices ...**

Matthew 13:53 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Iesous finished (ετελεσεν) **these parables ...**

Matthew 19:1 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Iesous finished (ετελεσεν) **these words ...**

Matthew 26:1 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Iesous finished (ετελεσεν) **all these words ...**

The five teaching blocks are all arranged in a symmetrical way and with matching themes.

Matthew 5:1-7:29 Sermon on the Mount in Galilee • 7:28 "When Jesus finished these words ..."	Matthew 10:1-42 Sending Speech • 11:1 "When Jesus finished instructing the twelve ..."	Matthew 13:1-52 Kingdom Parables • 13:52 "When Jesus finished these parables ..."	Matthew 18:1-35 Kingdom Ethics • 19:1 "When Jesus finished these words ..."	Matthew 23:1-25:46 Speeches in Jerusalem • 26:1 "When Jesus finished all these words ..."
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Matthew 5-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The opening and closing teachings are the longest, and they display matching designs and main themes, as summarized in the charts below.

Matthew 5:1-7:27		Sermon on the Mount	Matthew 23:1-25:46		Sermon about Jerusalem's Ruin
Matt. 5:1-16	Matt. 5:1-12	The 9 blessings on the disciples	Matt. 23:1-38	Matt. 23:1-12	The 7 woes on the Pharisees
	Matt. 5:13			Matt. 23:13-32	
	Matt. 5:14-16			Matt. 23:33-38	
Matt. 5:17-7:12	Matt. 5:17-48	Discourse on New Covenant righteousness	Matt. 24:1-50	Matt. 24:1-14	Discourse on the ruin of Jerusalem and the exaltation of the Son of Man
	Matt. 6:1-18			Matt. 24:15-35	
	Matt. 6:19-7:12			Matt. 24:36-50	
Matt. 7:13-27	Matt. 7:13-14	Three parables about the two ways: • Wide and narrow gates • Wolves and sheep • Stable house vs. unstable house	Matt. 25:1-46	Matt. 25:1-13	Three parables about the culmination of the ages: • Wise and foolish women • Wise and rebel slaves • Sheep and goats
	Matt. 7:15-23			Matt. 25:14-30	
	Matt. 7:24-27			Matt. 25:31-46	
Matthew Sermon Comparison. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).					

The three sections that make up the central body of Matthew advance the core themes and narrative claims made about Jesus.

1. Matthew 4:17-11:1 — Jesus is the Son of God, bringing the Kingdom of the skies down to Earth in word (chs. 5-7) and action (chs. 8-9) and then sending his disciples out to share in his mission (ch. 10).
2. Matthew 11:2-16:20 — Jesus' identity is developed and reacted to in different ways.
 - The disciples discern that Jesus is the Son of God.
 - The crowds come to see Jesus as the Son of David.
 - The authorities view Jesus as a deceiver and threat to be destroyed.
3. Matthew 16:21-25:46 — Jesus describes his identity as the Son of God come to suffer and die in Jerusalem for the sins of his people (chs. 16-20), so Jesus goes to the city (chs. 20-21) and engages the

Major Themes in Matthew's Gospel

Jesus, Son of David, Son of Abraham, Son of God

From the first line of the book, Jesus is introduced as a "son of David, son of Abraham" (Matt. 1:1), and not long after that, as "the son of God" (Matt. 3:17). These three aspects of Jesus' identity are uniquely highlighted and interconnected in Matthew.

"Son of David" = **Israel focused** : heir to Israel's royal and messianic hopes, as expressed in the Torah, Prophets, and Psalms. This is an Israel-focused role, so it explains the laser focus Jesus has in Matthew on his mission to Israel.

Matthew 1:20-21 NASB

²⁰ But when he had considered this, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, "Joseph, **son of David**, do not be afraid to take Mary as your wife; for the child who has been conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit. ²¹ She will bear a son; and you shall call his name Jesus, **for he will save his people from their sins.**"

Matthew 4:23 NASB

Jesus was **going throughout all Galilee**, teaching **in their synagogues** and proclaiming the gospel of the kingdom, and healing every kind of disease and every kind of sickness among the people.

Matthew 10:5-6 NASB

⁵ These twelve Jesus sent out after instructing them: "**Do not go in the way of the nations**, and do not enter any city of the Samaritans; ⁶ but rather **go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.**"

Matthew 15:22-24 NASB

²² And a Canaanite woman from that region came out and began to cry out, saying, "Have mercy on me, Lord, **Son of David**; my daughter is cruelly demon-possessed." ²³ But he did not answer her a word. And his disciples came and implored him, saying, "Send her away, because she keeps shouting at us." ²⁴ But he answered and said, "**I was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.**"

"Son of Abraham" = **nations focused** : the inheritor of the promise that, through Israel, God's blessing would go out to all nations. This is also a major theme in Matthew's Gospel because Jesus' launching of God's heavenly Kingdom on Earth was always meant to go out to the nations.

- Matthew 1:1-17: The four non-Israelite matriarches in Jesus' genealogy
- Matthew 2:1-2: The eastern astrologers who come to pay tribute and worship baby Jesus
- Matthew 8:5-13: The Roman centurion who bows before Jesus' healing power

Matthew 8:10-11 NASB

¹⁰ Now when Jesus heard this, he marveled and said to those who were following, “Truly I say to you, **I have not found such great faith with anyone in Israel.** ¹¹ I say to you that many will come from east and west, and **recline at the table with Abraham**, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven;”

- Matthew 15:31-39: Feeding a non-Israelite crowd with bread from Heaven

“Son of God and Son of Humanity” = **divine + human focused** : Matthew has combined the above two themes about Jesus’ identity (Son of David and Abraham) with a third unifying claim—in Jesus, the God of Israel has become personally present to bring God’s rescuing rule over both Israel and the nations. As the divine Son, he will surrender his cosmic authority in obedience to the will of his Father precisely so that he can identify with Israel and the nations in their sin-induced suffering and mortality. He will, after his death, be raised up to cosmic authority so that through the Son of David, the Messiah of Israel, the promise to Abraham of blessing for the nations can finally be fulfilled through a union of God with his people.

Matthew 1:22-23 NASB

²² Now all this took place to fulfill what was spoken by the Lord through the prophet:

²³ “Behold, the virgin shall be with child and shall bear **a son**, and they shall call his name Immanuel,” which translated means, **“God with us.”**

Matthew 3:16-17 NASB

¹⁶ After being baptized, Jesus came up immediately from the water; and behold, the heavens were opened, and he saw the Spirit of God descending as a dove and lighting on him, ¹⁷ and behold, a voice out of the heavens said, **“This is my beloved Son**, in whom I am well-pleased.”

Matthew 17:5 NASB

While he was still speaking, a bright cloud overshadowed them, and behold, a voice out of the cloud said, **“This is my beloved Son**, with whom I am well-pleased; listen to him!”

Matthew 17:22-23 NASB

²² And while they were gathering together in Galilee, Jesus said to them, **“The Son of humanity is going to be delivered into the hands of men;** ²³ and **they will kill him**, and **he will be raised** on the third day.” And they were deeply grieved.

Matthew 18:20 NASB

For where two or three have gathered together in my name, **I am there in the middle of them.**

Matthew 28:18-20 NASB

¹⁸ And Jesus came up and spoke to them, saying, **“All authority has been given to me in heaven and on earth.** ¹⁹ Go therefore and **make disciples of all the nations**, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit, ²⁰ teaching them to observe all that I commanded you; and look, **I am with you always, even to the end of the age.”**

Jesus, Moses, and the Messianic Torah

Matthew collects most of Jesus' teaching into five large blocks that are strategically placed in locations that symmetrically match on the macro-scale of the book. Each of these teachings concludes with the same phrase.

Matthew 7:28, 11:1, 13:53, 19:1, 26:1 NASB

And when Jesus finished (τελεω) speaking these words ...

Here, Matthew portrays Jesus on analogy with moments where Moses concludes a large delivery of covenant laws from Yahweh to Israel in the Torah.

Exodus 31:18 Instructor's Translation

And when he **finished** (συντελεω) speaking with him on Mount Sinai, he gave Moses the two tablets of the testimony, tablets of stone, written by the finger of God.

Deuteronomy 31:24 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Moses **finished** (συντελεω) **writing the words** of this Torah in a scroll until they were complete

Deuteronomy 32:45 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Moses **finished** (συντελεω) **speaking all these words** to Israel

In the Deuteronomy passages, it is Moses who has "finished" speaking the words of the Torah to the people. But notice that in Exodus 31:18, the first instance of this formula, it is Yahweh who finishes speaking to Moses, who will go and speak to Israel.

It is no coincidence that Matthew has placed Jesus' discussion about "fulfilling the Torah" (Matt. 5:17-21) near the beginning of the first teaching block. Jesus is presented as bringing about what Moses himself longed for in the Torah, that God's people would love their God and live by his will from the deepest desires of their heart. This is a uniquely major emphasis in Matthew's presentation of Jesus.

Deuteronomy 10:12-13 NASB

¹² Now, Israel, what does the LORD your God require from you, but to fear the LORD your God, to walk in all his ways and **love him**, and to serve the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul, ¹³ and to keep the LORD's commandments and His statutes which I am commanding you today for your good?

Deuteronomy 30:6 NASB

Moreover the LORD your God will circumcise your heart and the heart of your descendants, **to love the LORD your God with all your heart** and with all your soul, so that you may live.

Matthew 22:37-40 NASB

³⁷ And he said to him, "'You shall **love the Lord your God with all your heart**, and with all your soul, and with all your mind.'

³⁸ This is the great and foremost commandment.

³⁹ The second is like it, 'You shall **love your neighbor as yourself.**'

⁴⁰ **On these two commandments depend the whole Torah and the Prophets."**

Matthew 23:23 NASB

Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you tithe mint and dill and cummin, and have neglected **the weightier matters of the law: justice and mercy and faithfulness**; but these are the things you should have done without neglecting the others.

Jesus and the Messianic Community

Matthew has presented Jesus as the Son of David/Abraham/God and as a messianic revealer of the new covenant and fulfilled Torah, precisely to begin a renewal movement in Israel that will grow to include the nations. This is not a replacement of Israel, it is a renewal of Israel into communities that will expand to include the nations.

Only in Matthew does Jesus explicitly refer to his "community" (Grk. *ekklesia*).

Matthew 16:16-18 NASB*

¹⁶ Simon Peter answered, "You are the Messiah, the Son of the living God."

¹⁷ And Jesus said to him, "Blessed are you, Simon Barjona, because flesh and blood did not reveal this to you, but my Father who is in heaven. ¹⁸ I also say to you that you are Peter, and upon this rock I will build **my assembly**; and the gates of the grave will not overpower it."

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Matthew 18:17 NASB*

And if he refuses to listen to them, tell it to the church; and if he refuses to listen even to **the assembly**, let him be to you as a Gentile and a tax collector.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In both of these passages, Jesus is aware that he is beginning an "assembly" that has a unique social identity within Israel because of its association with himself.

The twelve disciples (= symbol of a renewed Israel!) are sent out by Jesus in order to take up his mission and expand its reach (Matt. 4:17).

Matthew 10:5-7 NASB

⁵ These twelve Jesus sent out after instructing them: "Do not go in the way of the Gentiles, and do not enter any city of the Samaritans; ⁶ but rather **go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.** ⁷ And as you go, preach, saying, '**The kingdom of heaven is at hand.**'"

Much of Jesus' teaching in Matthew is dedicated to ethical and social formation, so the community embodies the true fulfillment of Israel's Torah (chs. 5-7) and mirrors Jesus' own servant ethic (ch. 10 and ch. 18). Jesus anticipates that his assembly will include all kinds of people with all kinds of motives (ch. 13), which will all be sorted out in the transition from this age into the age to come (chs. 23-25).

Reflection Question

Matthew begins with a long genealogy. What themes are introduced here and developed throughout the rest of Matthew's Gospel?